



Spanish Expressions Cheat Sheet

Castilian Spanish — Natural speech, reactions, slang & refranes

☀ Swearing & Expletives

The expressions Spaniards actually use. Hostia and joder are your bread and butter — learn these first.

Spanish	Literal	Natural English Equivalent	Usage / Tone
¡Hostia!	Host (Eucharist)	Fuck! / Shit! / Bloody hell!	Shock, surprise, pain — very common in Spain
¡Hostia puta!	—	Holy fucking shit!	Intensified version — stronger shock
¡Me cago en todo!	I shit on everything	For fuck's sake! / Jesus Christ!	Extreme frustration
¡Me cago en la leche!	I shit in the milk	For fuck's sake!	Classic Spanish — everyday frustration
¡Me cago en dios!	I shit on God	Jesus fucking Christ!	Strong — use carefully in company
¡La hostia!	The host	No fucking way! / That's insane!	Can express amazement positively or negatively
¡Joder!	Fuck (to fuck)	Fuck! / Shit! / Come on!	All-purpose — like 'bloody hell', Spain's most used
¡Joder tío/tía!	—	Fuck me mate / Jesus mate	Casual frustration or surprise with a friend
¡Qué coño...!	What cunt...	What the fuck...!	Annoyed, confused — 'qué coño haces?' = WTF are you doing?
¿Pero qué haces, coño?	—	What the fuck are you doing?!	Direct equivalent — coño adds the punch
¡Qué cojones!	What balls!	What the fuck! / Bollocks!	Disbelief or indignation
¡Me la suda!	—	I don't give a fuck / couldn't care less	Strong indifference — vulgar
¡Que te den!	—	Fuck off! / Get fucked!	Dismissal — equivalent to 'piss off' strongly
¡Vete a la mierda!	Go to the shit	Go fuck yourself!	Direct and aggressive
¡Mierda!	Shit	Shit!	Universal — same as English
¡Ostras!	Oysters	Shit! / Bloody hell! (milder)	Polite substitute for '¡Hostia!' — safe in public
¡Venga ya!	Come on already!	Oh come on! / Give me a break! / No way!	Disbelief or dismissal
¡No me jodas!	Don't fuck me	You're kidding! / No fucking way!	Disbelief — also 'stop messing me around'

¡Qué putada!	What a whore-ing	What a pain in the arse / That's shit	When something is really annoying or unfair
¡Me la pela!	—	I couldn't give a shit	Very vulgar version of not caring
¡Qué follón!	What a fucking mess	What a mess / What a shit show!	Chaos, disorder — less vulgar, more everyday
¡Eres un cabrón!	You're a male goat	You bastard! / You fucker!	Can be affectionate between mates or genuinely insulting
¡Hijo de puta!	Son of a whore	Son of a bitch!	Direct insult — context determines severity

⚡ Everyday Reactions & Responses

Things you'll say and hear constantly in daily life. *Venga* alone has about fifteen meanings — context is everything.

Spanish	Meaning / Use	Natural English Equivalent
¡Venga!	Agreement, encouragement, let's go	Come on! / Let's go! / Deal! / Alright!
Venga, vale.	Soft agreement / wrapping up	Yeah, alright. / Sure, fine.
¡Dale!	Go for it / do it	Go on! / Yeah! / Do it!
¡Tío/Tía!	Mate, dude (neutral)	Mate / Bro / Dude / Love
¡Qué va!	No way, that's not right	No way! / Not at all! / Come off it!
¡Hombre!	Man (exclamation)	Oh come on! / Mate! / Oh wow! (tone-dependent)
¡Anda!	Walk! (exclamation)	Wow! / Really? / No way! / Oh come on!
¡Anda ya!	—	Oh come on! / Get out of here! / Yeah right!
¡Buenas!	Short for good morning/afternoon	Hey! / Alright! / Hi!
¿Qué hay?	What is there?	What's up? / How's it going?
¿Qué pasa?	What's happening?	What's up? / What's going on?
¿Todo bien?	Everything good?	You alright? / All good?
Más o menos.	More or less	So-so / Not bad / Could be worse
Ahí ahí.	There there	So-so / Yeah, kind of (Valencia uses this a lot)
Ni idea.	No idea	No idea / Haven't got a clue
Eso es.	That's it	Exactly / That's right / Spot on
Claro que sí.	Of course yes	Of course / Absolutely
Claro que no.	Of course no	Of course not / Absolutely not
Tranquilo/a.	Calm/tranquil	Chill / Don't worry / Easy there

Qué fuerte.	How strong	That's intense / No way / That's mad
Qué rollo.	What a roll	What a bore / What a drag / So tedious
Qué pereza.	What laziness	I can't be bothered / Such a drag
¡Ya está!	It's already done!	That's it! / Done! / There you go!
¡Ya era hora!	It was already time!	About bloody time! / Finally!
¡Por fin!	Finally!	Finally! / At last!

✅ Agreement, Disagreement & Fillers

How to agree, push back, or buy time — naturally. These are the glue of conversation.

Spanish	Natural English Equivalent	Tone
Vale, vale.	Yeah yeah / Alright alright	Casual agreement or mild dismissal
De acuerdo.	Agreed / Fine by me	Neutral, formal-ish agreement
Me parece bien.	That works for me / Sounds good	Relaxed approval
Ni hablar.	No way / Absolutely not / Out of the question	Strong refusal
Para nada.	Not at all / No way / Absolutely not	Flat denial
Desde luego.	Of course / Absolutely / Obviously	Strong agreement or exasperated 'obviously'
¡Exacto!	Exactly! / Precisely!	Confirming someone's point
¡Qué razón tienes!	You're so right!	Enthusiastic agreement
No sé yo...	I'm not so sure... / Hmm, I don't know...	Polite scepticism
Yo qué sé.	How should I know / I dunno	Mild exasperation or genuine ignorance
A ver...	Let's see... / Hmm... / Look...	Thinking pause, or introducing a point
Mira...	Look... / Listen...	Introducing a point, sometimes defensive
O sea...	I mean... / Like... / So basically...	Clarifying or trailing thought
En plan...	Like... / Kind of... / In a way...	Filler — very common in Spain's youth speech

💡 Filler & Connective Phrases

These make you sound fluent. Spaniards use pues, es que, and a ver constantly — master these to stop sounding textbook.

Spanish	When you say it	English Equivalent
Bueno...	Transitioning, soft pause	Well... / So... / Right...
Pues...	Thinking, starting an answer	Well... / Hmm... / So...
Pues mira...	Starting an explanation	Well, look... / Thing is...
Es que...	Giving a reason/excuse	The thing is... / It's just that...
A ver si...	Hoping something happens	Hopefully... / Let's see if...
Si es que...	Expressing exasperation at the obvious	I mean, obviously... / The thing is...
¿Sabes?	Checking understanding / emphasis	You know? / Right? / Know what I mean?
¿Me entiendes?	Do you understand me?	You get me? / You know what I mean?
¿Ves?	See what I mean?	See? / You see?
La verdad es que...	Being honest	To be honest... / Truth is...
Al final...	Concluding / in the end	In the end... / At the end of the day...
O lo que sea.	Or whatever	Or whatever / Or something like that
Tal cual.	Just as it is	Exactly as it is / Word for word / Literally
Sin más.	Without more	Just like that / Plain and simple / No big deal
Lo que tú digas.	Whatever you say	Whatever you say / Sure, if you say so

Classic Refranes (Sayings)

Worth knowing for recognition more than production — Spaniards use these but they can sound forced from learners. Great for understanding.

Refrán	Literal Translation	English Equivalent / Meaning
No hay mal que por bien no venga.	No bad that doesn't come from good	Every cloud has a silver lining
A quien madruga, Dios le ayuda.	God helps the early riser	The early bird catches the worm
Más vale tarde que nunca.	Better late than never	Better late than never
Más vale pájaro en mano que ciento volando.	Better one bird in hand than a hundred flying	A bird in the hand is worth two in the bush
No todo lo que brilla es oro.	Not everything that shines is gold	All that glitters is not gold
El que mucho abarca, poco aprieta.	He who grasps much, squeezes little	Bite off more than you can chew
A mal tiempo, buena cara.	To bad weather, a good face	Make the best of a bad situation / Keep smiling

Camarón que se duerme, se lo lleva la corriente.	The shrimp that falls asleep gets swept away	Snooze you lose / Stay sharp
No hay peor ciego que el que no quiere ver.	No worse blind than one who won't see	There's none so blind as those who won't see
Dime con quién andas, y te diré quién eres.	Tell me who you walk with, I'll tell you who you are	You are the company you keep
Ojos que no ven, corazón que no siente.	Eyes that don't see, heart that doesn't feel	Out of sight, out of mind
No metas la pata.	Don't put your leg/paw in it	Don't put your foot in it / Don't screw up
Cada oveja con su pareja.	Each sheep with its partner	Birds of a feather flock together
El hábito no hace al monje.	The habit doesn't make the monk	Clothes don't make the man

Regional note: This sheet is calibrated for Castilian Spanish as spoken in Spain (Valencia). Some expressions may differ in Latin America.